Stephen A. Wenzel

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Education

Meredith College

Master of Arts in Biomedical Sciences, *August 2026 - May 2027 (Expected)*

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

B.S. in Biology, Minor in Chemistry and Neuroscience, *August 2018 - May 2022*

Dean's List in Spring 2022

Clinical Experience

Volunteer Ophthalmic Assistant Trainer

ABCCM Medical Ministry | Asheville, NC

January 2026 - July 2026

- Performed ophthalmic screenings for underserved patients, providing vision testing for a predominantly Spanish-speaking population without access to insurance or government healthcare programs
- Collaborated with the optometrist and volunteer leadership to establish the ophthalmology clinic and implement standardized workflows for patient vision assessments
- Trained clinic staff to independently operate ophthalmic diagnostic equipment, including autorefractors and Optos retinal imaging systems, and developed instructional materials to support ongoing staff education and continuity of care

Certified Ophthalmic Assistant

Duke Eye Center - Retina & Glaucoma | Durham, NC

September 2024 - November 2025

- Earned the **Certified Ophthalmic Assistant (COA)** credential, qualifying for advanced responsibilities including surgical measurements, patient preparation for the inherited retinal disease clinic, and training of new employees
- Completed comprehensive ophthalmic evaluations supporting up to 9 physicians daily, including OCT imaging, anterior segment exams, refractions, and visual field testing
- Administered dilating agents, intraocular pressure-lowering medications, and topical anesthetics under physician supervision
- Upheld Joint Commission standards and supported quality assurance initiatives to maintain patient safety compliance

Medical Assistant

Western Carolina Ear, Nose, and Throat Specialists, PLLC | Clyde, NC

August 2023 - June 2024

- Managed patient triage and collected detailed medical histories for 20 to 25 patients daily during outpatient clinic visits
- Assisted physicians and physician assistants with clinical exams, in-office procedures, specimen collection, and minor surgeries
- Scribed patient encounters and maintained electronic medical records for accuracy
- Ensured OSHA compliance through instrument sterilization and autoclave operations to maintain infection control standards

Ophthalmic Assistant

Mountain Eye Associates | Clyde, NC

May 2022 - April 2023

- Conducted diagnostic testing, including OCT imaging, refraction, and visual field analysis, for 14 to 16 patients daily
- Prepared patients for cataract surgeries and in-office laser procedures
- Administered ophthalmic medications following strict physician protocols

Selected Shadowing Experience

Otolaryngology: Jacob Jennings, PA-C | 176 hours

Western Carolina Ear, Nose, and Throat Specialists, PLLC | Clyde, NC

Ophthalmology: Dr. Pratap Challa, MD; Dr. Stuart McKinnon, MD, PhD | 21 hours

Duke Department of Ophthalmology | Retina & Glaucoma | Durham, NC

Dermatology: Phaedra Hockman, PA-C; Hannah Seville, PA-C | 24 hours

Mountain Laurel Dermatology | Clyde, NC

Research Experience

Undergraduate Research Assistant

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill - Rogers Laboratory | Chapel Hill, NC

August 2021 - May 2022

- Studied how cytoskeletal drug treatments affect microtubule acetylation and mitochondrial transport in *Drosophila melanogaster*
- Reviewed scientific literature to inform experimental design and data interpretation
- Performed fluorescence microscopy and generated kymographs to analyze mitochondrial movement
- Presented research findings via poster at the University of North Carolina Undergraduate Research Expo

Undergraduate Research Assistant

UNC Adams School of Dentistry | Chapel Hill, NC

June 2020 - December 2020

- Conducted systematic literature reviews across biomedical and educational databases to support research on competency-based medical education and healthcare professional assessment
- Screened, organized, and synthesized peer-reviewed literature using standardized inclusion criteria and Microsoft Excel, improving the efficiency and consistency of qualitative research analysis
- Collaborated with faculty researchers to examine definitions of professional competence and Entrustable Professional Activities (EPAs), contributing to the development of a shared framework for health professions education and admissions

Teaching & Leadership

Duke MINDs Learn Committee | *June 2025 - November 2025*

- Organized professional development programs and networking events for early-career Duke employees
- Contributed to cross-departmental planning of recurring events supporting career growth and connection among hospital staff

Marching Band Assistant | *Fall Semesters of 2023 and 2024*

- Guided section leaders and drum majors on leadership skills and season-long planning
- Collaborated with instructors and volunteers to strengthen student musical performance and team engagement

Assistant Scoutmaster | *November 2022 - November 2023*

- Mentored more than 20 Scouts working toward rank advancement and guided several candidates through the Eagle Scout process
- Coordinated monthly with district leaders to help build the troop and organize community service projects

Organic Chemistry II Peer Mentor | *August 2021 - May 2022*

- Led weekly peer mentoring sessions on reaction mechanisms, problem-solving, and core chemistry concepts for groups of 20+ students
- Partnered with UNC Chapel Hill faculty and fellow mentors to help students in a 200-person course stay engaged and improve academic performance

Volunteer Experience

Patient Experience Volunteer | *November 2024 - November 2025*

Duke University Hospital | Durham, NC

- **Recipient, 2025 Most Supportive Volunteer Award**, Duke University Hospital System
- Supported two nursing teams in enhancing care and comfort for more than 30 patients across several medical-surgical units
- Welcomed patients and visitors while organizing clinical equipment and hospital unit resources

Undergraduate COVID-19 Test Site Volunteer | *August 2021 - April 2022*

Carolina COVID-19 Student Services Corps (CSSC) | Chapel Hill, NC

- Directed more than 30 students and staff weekly through onsite COVID-19 testing procedures
- Collected laboratory specimens and coordinated directly with pathology personnel
- Explained testing protocols and public health recommendations to community members

Certifications & Honors

Certified Ophthalmic Assistant (COA) | JCAHPO | *active June 2025 - June 2028*

Basic Life Support (BLS/CPR & AED) | American Heart Association | *active September 2024 - September 2026*

Recipient, Eagle Scout Award | Boy Scouts of America | October 2017